



GARISSA UNIVERSITY

SCHOOL OF EDUCATION, ARTS AND SOCIAL SCIENCES

Concept Paper Writing Guide

Concept Paper

What is a concept paper and why is it necessary?

A concept paper sometimes called a pre-proposal or preliminary proposal is a document that serves the following purposes:

1. Provide a clear summary and give an idea to the faculty members what the proposed research will be about in order to appoint relevant supervisors who will assist in the development of a research proposal.
2. To attract funding. This serves as a request for funding by sending a summary of the proposed research proposal to the relevant prospective funders. If it is for this purpose, then the candidate must give a proposed budget and a timeframe for his/her study.

Elements of a Concept Paper

Title of the proposed study

Generally, a research title should reflect among other things the variable (s), the population under study, methodological component and location of the study.

1. Introduction

Your introduction serves as a summary of what is contained in your concept paper. It should be short and clear, taking less than a quarter a page.

2. Background to the Study

Background information of research is the historical information about the problem under study from all parts of the world, within the region, country and study area levels (see Fig. 1). While literature review which is sometimes contradicted and overlaps with the background information is about what others have written about your problem, background information is about how the problem being investigated has existed over time in different parts of the world in relation to the study variables.

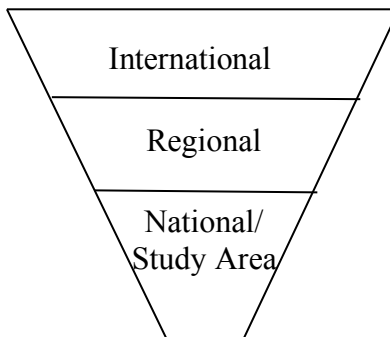


Figure 1. Arrangement of background information

3. Statement of the Problem

At this stage as Gall, Gall and Borg (2003); Gay, Mills and Aisarian (2006); and Bell (1999) note, the researcher must come out clear that indeed there is a problem that is worth taking the researcher's time, energy and money for a long period of time. Justify the study and stress why the specified problem is worth investigating. Like the background information, a research problem should contain all the study variables under study. The variables should also have a reflection of consistent negative aspects of the problem that forms the basis for the study. However, care should be taken not to pre-empt the problem under investigation through the variables.

4. Purpose of the Study

The purpose statement is a statement that advances the overall direction or focus for the study. The purpose statement contains the major focus of the study, the participants in the study, and the location or site of the inquiry.

Example: *The purpose of this study is to examine the relationship between use of Internet communication between teachers and parents in a Midwestern school district and student achievement on tests in high school social studies* (Creswell, 2012).

Example: *The purpose of this study is to examine the academic performance of secondary schools in Garissa County in the era of decentralization in Kenya.*

This purpose statement is then narrowed to research objectives you want achieve, questions you plan to answer or hypothesis you wish to test.

5. Objectives of the Study

A good research project should tell the reader what it is meant to achieve.

It is always advisable to begin with “To” for example:

- To examine the relationship between the efficiency of managing decentralized resources by the principals and secondary school academic performance in Garissa County.
- To establish whether there is a relationship between the resources availed for use in secondary schools and academic performance in Garissa County.

The researcher has to see to it that the objectives are independent from one another, they possess independent and dependent variables that are connected to the research study area and that they have a total connection to the research problem and topic.

6. Research Questions (Research Questions or Hypotheses)

The researcher has to formulate questions that have to be answered by the study. Like research objectives and hypotheses, research questions must be independent from one another, they possess independent and dependent variables that are connected to the research study area and that they have a total connection to the research problem and topic.

Examples include:

- What is the relationship between efficiency in managing decentralized resources by the principals and secondary schools’ academic performance in Garissa County?
- What is the relationship between the level of resources availed for use in secondary schools and academic performance in Garissa County?

7. Statement of the Hypotheses (Hypotheses or Research Questions)

Kerlinger (1968) asserts that “hypothesis is the most powerful tool man has invented to achieve dependable knowledge” (p. 27). They are tentative, intelligent guesses or speculations posited for the purpose of directing one’s thinking and action towards the solution of a problem (Selamat,

2008; Bryman, 2004). Hypotheses may be stated in null, alternative or in statement form. However, out of the three forms, stating in null form is widely used. Examples include:

- There is no significant relationship between the efficiency in managing decentralized resources by the principals and secondary school academic performance in Garissa County.
- There is no significant relationship between the level of resources availed for use in secondary schools and academic performance in Garissa County.

8. Significance of the Study

At this stage, the researcher must state how the study will be beneficial to society, government, stakeholders and/or to the organization he/she is working for. In other words, what contributions do you think your study intends to make to the advancement of knowledge and/or to the solution of some practical or theoretical problem(s)?

9. Assumptions

What assumptions have you made, or what have you taken for granted about the nature of the aspects that you are investigating? Unlike hypotheses, assumptions here are not testable but are statements about observations and experiences related to the study variables and that are taken for granted or are assumed to be true. The researcher has to put them down but they should not be obvious statements they should be based on the study variables.

10. Limitations

Limitations are the unavoidable conditions (not within your control) surrounding your study and within which conclusions to the study must be confined.

11. Delimitations

Delimitations are the characteristics that limit the scope and describe the boundaries of the study, such as the sample size, geographical location or setting in which the study takes place, population traits, etc. Additionally, the researcher might also choose to use some research tools and methodologies to collect data but not others. These delimitations might be imposed for practical reasons, such as lack of time or financial resources to carry out a more thorough investigation. The delimitation section of the study should explain why specific choices were made while others were excluded and how this might affect the outcome of the research.

12. Literature Review

The researcher has to summarize what is contained here indicating headings under variables in form of what others have written about the topic under study. Like background information, for each variable the researcher has to present it in an international, regional and national perspective.

13. Theoretical Framework

Mention theories/models that will be used in your research and state how they are connected to the study.

14. Conceptual Framework

Show with the aid of a figure the variables that will be used in your study. Figure 2 has an idea on how this should be presented. Note that the arrows have meaning.

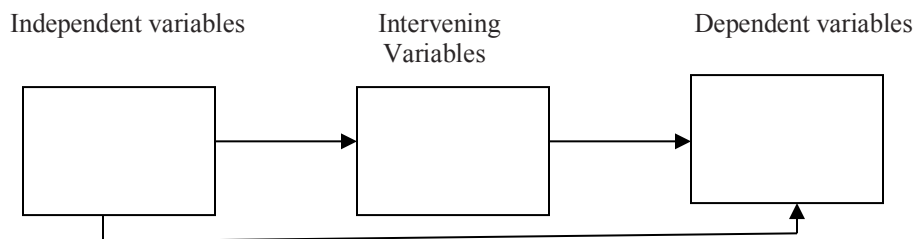


Figure 2. Conceptual Framework

15. Research Methodology

a. Research Method

Mention a method selected for use (qualitative, quantitative or mixed model) and give reasons why the method is preferred.

b. Research Design

Select a suitable design for your study e.g. cross-sectional (survey), longitudinal, case study, experimental and comparative and state its suitability in connection to the method(s) used.

c. Location of the Study

The researcher should indicate where his/her research will take place in a brief description. A description based on latitudes and longitudes, distance from a conspicuous place or point e.g. capital city, neighboring districts, etc can serve the purpose.

d. Population of the Study (Target Population)

According to Gay, Mills and Airasian (2006) and Bryman (2016), target population is the total number of items involved in research.

The researcher should describe the target population explicitly in terms of numbers and geographical limits. A tabulation of the data where necessary will be a better presentation to the reader.

e. Sampling Procedure

We can only get from the population to the sample through sampling; therefore describe the sampling procedure that you will use to select the sample from the population described in d. For example as Gay et al (2006) and Bryman (2016) contend, the general minimum sample size criterion (30%) in most cases does apply in the selection of the accessible population from the target population in quantitative studies. They further note that for qualitative research, the use of a lower percentage to arrive at sample size is acceptable provided the respondents are key informants.

f. The Sample Size

When selecting participants for a study, it is important to determine the size of the sample you will need. A general rule of thumb is to select as large a sample as possible from the population (Creswell, 2012). The larger the sample, the less the potential error is that the sample will be different from the population.

As a product of the sampling procedure, present this in a tabular form if possible.

g. Instrumentation

What instrument(s) are you going to use to collect data for the study? If the instrument to be used is constructed by you, describe clearly, with accurate details, how the set of items for use were designed to illicit responses for each variable were constructed, or how you arrived at the set of items which you are using as an operational definition of each of the variables.

h. Validity and reliability of Instruments

Give and tell how you will ascertain validity and reliability of instruments.

i. Data Collection Procedure

Ethical issues need to be adhered to at all times in research (Bryman 2016; Gall, et al (2003). Explain the procedure of data collection starting from your supervisors and university.

j. Ethical Considerations

Narrate all the ethical issues that you will consider in your planned research.

k. Data Analysis Methods

Give the data analysis methods for your chosen strategy e.g. Pearson r , ANOVA, t -tests, Chi square, Focus by Question Analysis Strategy, etc.

-----**End of Concept Paper Writing Guide**-----

Notes:

1. Concept Paper should have between 3-5 pages
2. 1.5 spaced
3. Use times New Roman
4. Written in future tense
5. Use “12”
6. Written in an APA 6th Edition style.
7. Should have all citations, quotations and references in APA 6th Edition style.
8. Indication of chapters is not necessary.
9. An abstract is not necessary but it should have a title and introduction
10. Proper referencing in an APA 6th Edition format should be adhered to.

-----Dr. Gori-----